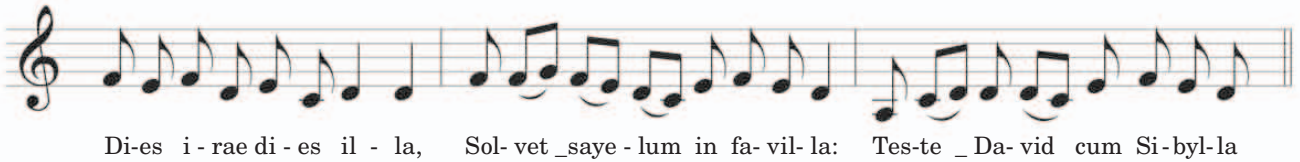


Using modes

Due to its dramatic potential in sound and image, the *Dies Irae* plainchant has fascinated composers for centuries. Shown below is the original chant, and a parody of it made by the French composer Hector Berlioz in the finale of his *Symphonie Fantastique*. Berlioz uses the chant both as a narrative device within his story (an artist who is in love and has a nightmare that he has gone to hell), but also for its clash with the musical language of his own time.

▽ *Dies Irae*

This famous medieval plainchant describes in graphic terms the Day of Wrath that will announce the Last Judgement. It is in the Dorian mode.

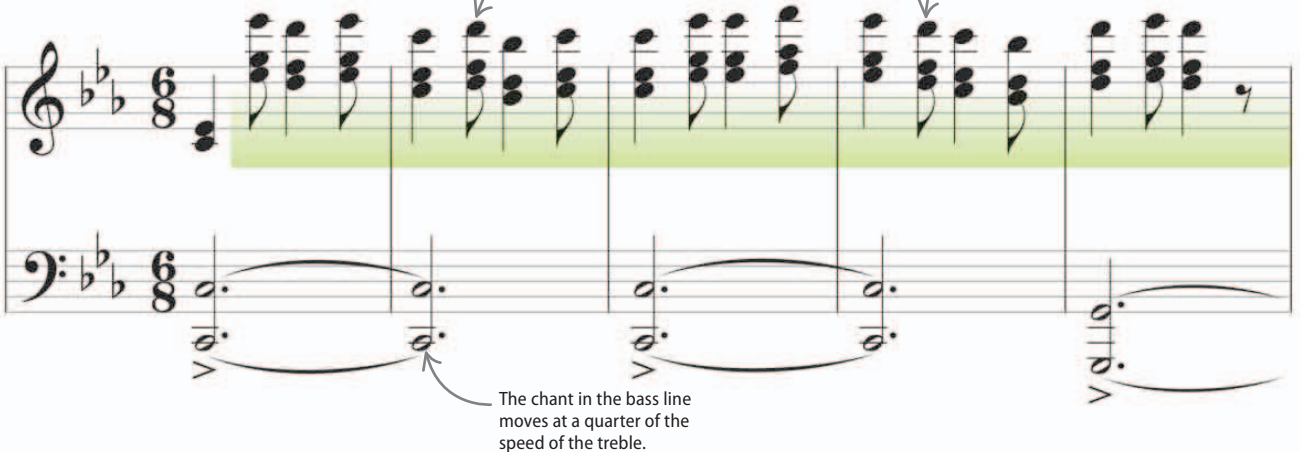


▽ *Symphonie Fantastique, finale*

Here the *Dies Irae* is quoted in the treble clef. It reappears in the bass later on, but moves much more slowly.

Standard practice is not to write in parallel thirds. Berlioz deliberately breaks the rules.

Berlioz uses a syncopated-style rhythm with the modal melody, completely out of keeping with its original character.



REAL WORLD

The Day of Judgement

The “*Dies Irae*” is a medieval Latin hymn that formed part of the Catholic mass for the dead. Translating as “Day of Wrath,” it describes the Last Judgement, which in the Catholic religion marks the end of the world. This Renaissance mural shows Christ, surrounded by the saints, sending believers to heaven and casting unbelievers down to hell.



“**Passionate subjects must be dealt with in cold blood.**”
Hector Berlioz